An unlikely 23 runs were required from the last over and, although JP did his best and fought till the end, we finished seven runs short.

Our dressing room was very quiet afterwards. Nobody said the C-word. Nobody needed to say the C-word. Each player sat alone with his thoughts, coping with the knowledge that his family and friends would be sharing the gut-wrenching disappointment at home, realising that cricket fans around the world would be thinking the Proteas had choked again.

Mickey remained wholly positive. 'OK, it didn't go our way today,' he said, 'but we've played some fantastic cricket here and this team needs to look forward. We're going to host the ICC Champions Trophy tournament in South Africa in September and we'll be ready.'

He was right, of course, and the stage was set, surely. We were ranked the No. 1 ODI team in the world, and were playing at home, with each of our three pool matches scheduled for SuperSport Park in Centurion. At last, the dice were loaded in our favour, surely. This was our time, surely.

Sri Lanka were our first opponents, and we ran into Tillakaratne Dilshan, who crashed 106 off 92 balls and helped his team to reach a total of 319 in 50 overs. Graeme led from the front again, but our pursuit lacked conviction and, almost literally, dissolved in the rain that fell in the evening. In the end, we were well beaten by 55 runs on the Duckworth/Lewis method. Where we had anticipated excited euphoria, we found damp disappointment.

The weather had scarcely improved when we played New Zealand at the same venue two days later and, under grey skies, the Kiwis batted first and scrambled to 214, something for them to defend.

Ideally, in such situations, in such tournaments, the Proteas would return to their dressing room, chase a reasonable target with the minimum fuss and get the job done. In that perfect world, bowlers would bowl and batters would bat, we would all field with intensity and that would be that.